Asian Options by Monte Carlo: Arithmetic Pricing with the Geometric Control Variate

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Abstract

Asian options pay on a time-average of the underlying rather than its terminal value. The arithmetic-average Asian call has no closed form (the arithmetic average of lognormals is not lognormal), so Monte Carlo is the standard pricing tool. The geometric-average Asian call *does* have a closed form, because the geometric mean of lognormals is lognormal. The two averages are very highly correlated under typical parameters ($\rho > 0.999$ for a one-year ATM call with daily monitoring), so the geometric Asian is a near-perfect control variate for the arithmetic Asian. This note derives the closed form for the geometric Asian, implements the three pricers (arithmetic IID, geometric IID, arithmetic with geometric CV), and demonstrates a variance reduction factor on the order of 10^3 at the canonical ATM point.

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1 Path-dependent payoffs and the Asian family

A *path-dependent* option pays at maturity according to the trajectory of the underlying, not just its terminal value. Define a discrete monitoring grid $0 = t_0 < t_1 < \cdots < t_N = T$ (here equispaced: $t_k = kT/N$), and let $S_k \overset{\text{def}}{=} S_{t_k}$.

The two Asian averages are:

$$\bar{S} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} S_k \qquad \text{(arithmetic average)}, \tag{1}$$

$$\tilde{S} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \left(\prod_{k=1}^{N} S_k\right)^{1/N} \qquad \text{(geometric average)}. \tag{2}$$

Note that S_0 is excluded from both averages (it is the known spot, not part of the random history).

The arithmetic-average call pays $\max(\bar{S} - K, 0)$ at T; its risk-neutral price is

$$C^A \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} e^{-rT}\,\mathbb{E}[\max(\bar{S} - K, 0)]. \tag{3}$$

The geometric-average call pays $\max(\tilde{S} - K, 0)$ with price C^G analogously.

Why arithmetic Asian has no closed form. Under GBM, each S_k is lognormal. The product of lognormals is lognormal (the log is a sum of normals), so $\tilde{S}$ is lognormal. But the *sum* of lognormals is not lognormal, so $\bar{S}$ is not lognormal. There is no known elementary distribution for $\bar{S}$, hence no Black-Scholes formula. Monte Carlo is the workhorse tool.

Why geometric Asian has a closed form. As noted, $\log \tilde{S} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} \log S_k$, which is normal because each $\log S_k$ is normal. The first two moments determine the distribution; we compute them explicitly in Section 2.

2 Closed form for the geometric Asian call

Under risk-neutral GBM,

$$S_k \;=\; S_0 \exp\big((r - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2)t_k + \sigma W_{t_k}\big), \tag{4}$$

so

$$\log S_k \;=\; \log S_0 + (r - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2)t_k + \sigma W_{t_k}. \tag{5}$$

2.1 Mean and variance of $\log \tilde{S}$

Take the average over k:

$$\log \tilde{S} \;=\; \log S_0 + (r - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2)\cdot\frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} t_k + \sigma\cdot\frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} W_{t_k}. \tag{6}$$

With equispaced monitoring $t_k = kT/N$:

$$\frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} t_k \;=\; \frac{T}{N^2}\sum_{k=1}^{N} k \;=\; \frac{T(N+1)}{2N}. \tag{7}$$

So the mean is

$$\mu_G \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \mathbb{E}[\log \tilde{S}] \;=\; \log S_0 + (r - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2)\cdot\frac{T(N+1)}{2N}. \tag{8}$$

For the variance, we need

$$\operatorname{Var}\left(\frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} W_{t_k}\right) \;=\; \frac{1}{N^2}\sum_{j=1}^{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N}\operatorname{Cov}(W_{t_j}, W_{t_k}) \;=\; \frac{1}{N^2}\sum_{j,k}\min(t_j, t_k). \tag{9}$$

Using $t_k = kT/N$:

$$\frac{1}{N^2}\sum_{j,k}\min(t_j,t_k) \;=\; \frac{T}{N^3}\sum_{j,k}\min(j,k). \tag{10}$$

The double sum $\sum_{j,k}\min(j,k)$ over $\{1,\dots,N\}^2$ equals

$$\sum_{j=1}^{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N}\min(j,k) \;=\; \sum_{m=1}^{N} m\cdot(2(N-m)+1) \;=\; \frac{N(N+1)(2N+1)}{6}. \tag{11}$$

(The identity $\sum_{m=1}^{N} m(2N-2m+1) = \frac{N(N+1)(2N+1)}{6}$ is a standard finite sum manipulation.) So

$$\mathrm{Var}\left(\frac{1}{N}\sum W_{t_k}\right) \;=\; \frac{T(N+1)(2N+1)}{6N^2}, \tag{12}$$

and

$$\sigma_G^2 \;\stackrel{\text{def}}{=}\; \mathrm{Var}(\log\tilde{S}) \;=\; \sigma^2\cdot\frac{T(N+1)(2N+1)}{6N^2}. \tag{13}$$

2.2 Effective parameters and the Black-Scholes formula

We have $\log\tilde{S}\sim\mathcal{N}(\mu_G,\sigma_G^2)$, so $\tilde{S}$ is lognormal. Define the *effective volatility*

$$\sigma_{\text{eff}} \;\stackrel{\text{def}}{=}\; \sigma\sqrt{\frac{(N+1)(2N+1)}{6N^2}}. \tag{14}$$

Note $\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2\cdot T = \sigma_G^2$. To match the standard BS form, we want to write

$$\log\tilde{S} \;=\; \log S_0 + (r_{\text{eff}} - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2)T + \sigma_{\text{eff}}\sqrt{T}\tilde{Z} \tag{15}$$

for some standard normal $\tilde{Z}$. Matching means:

$$r_{\text{eff}}\cdot T - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2 T \;=\; (r-\tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2)\cdot\frac{T(N+1)}{2N}, \tag{16}$$

so

$$r_{\text{eff}} \;=\; \frac{(N+1)}{2N}(r-\tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2) + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2. \tag{17}$$

Then the geometric Asian call has Black-Scholes form, but with discounting at r (the original risk-free rate, since we *discount*, not *drift*, the geometric average):

$$\boxed{C^G \;=\; e^{-rT}\left[S_0 e^{r_{\text{eff}}\,T}\,\Phi(d_1) - K\,\Phi(d_2)\right]} \tag{18}$$

where

$$d_1 = \frac{\log(S_0/K) + (r_{\text{eff}} + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2)\,T}{\sigma_{\text{eff}}\sqrt{T}}, \qquad d_2 = d_1 - \sigma_{\text{eff}}\sqrt{T}. \tag{19}$$

Sanity check at $N\to\infty$. As N grows,

$$\frac{(N+1)(2N+1)}{6N^2} \;\to\; \frac{1}{3},$$

so $\sigma_{\text{eff}}\to\sigma/\sqrt{3}$. This reproduces the classical result that the continuous-monitoring geometric Asian behaves as a vanilla call with volatility $\sigma/\sqrt{3}$. Good sanity check.

Sanity check at $N = 1$. With $N = 1$ the geometric average reduces to S_T itself, so C^G should reduce to the vanilla call price. Plugging in:

$$\sigma_{\text{eff}}^2 = \sigma^2 \cdot \frac{2 \cdot 3}{6} = \sigma^2, \quad r_{\text{eff}} = (r - \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2) \cdot 1 + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2 = r,$$

so $C^G = e^{-rT}[S_0 e^{rT}\Phi(d_1) - K\Phi(d_2)] = S_0\Phi(d_1) - Ke^{-rT}\Phi(d_2)$, the standard BS formula. Verified.

3 Why geometric is a near-perfect control for arithmetic

The geometric and arithmetic means satisfy the AM-GM inequality: $\tilde{S} \leq \bar{S}$ pointwise. Moreover, on a single GBM path, both quantities respond to the same randomness (the same Brownian increments), so they are highly correlated. We can quantify how high.

Heuristic argument. Write $X_k = \log S_k$. Then

$$\log \tilde{S} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_k X_k, \qquad \log \bar{S} = \log\left(\frac{1}{N}\sum_k e^{X_k}\right).$$

For small relative variation in $\{X_k\}$ (which holds for moderate $\sigma\sqrt{T}$ and reasonable N), $\log \bar{S} \approx \log \tilde{S} + \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Var}_k(X_k)$ by a Taylor expansion of the log-sum-exp around its mean. The correction is small, of order $\sigma^2 T$, and fluctuates far less than $\log \tilde{S}$ itself, so $\operatorname{Corr}(\log \tilde{S}, \log \bar{S}) \to 1$ in this regime. Note that the AM-GM inequality only fixes the sign of the gap; the correlation comes from its smallness.

In practice, for a 1-year ATM call with $\sigma = 0.20$ and $N = 50$ monitoring dates, empirical correlation between $\bar{S} - K$ and $\tilde{S} - K$ exceeds 0.9999 on 10^4 Monte Carlo paths.

Implication for variance reduction. The control variate identity of the note on control variates gives, for paired estimators $X = e^{-rT}\max(\bar{S} - K, 0)$ and $Y = e^{-rT}\max(\tilde{S} - K, 0)$,

$$\operatorname{Var}(X - \beta^\star Y) \;=\; \operatorname{Var}(X)(1 - \rho^2), \tag{20}$$

where $\beta^\star = \operatorname{Cov}(X, Y)/\operatorname{Var}(Y)$ and $\rho = \operatorname{Corr}(X, Y)$. With $\rho \approx 0.9999$, the variance reduction factor is $1/(1 - \rho^2) \approx 5\,000$. This is by far the most powerful control variate in the Monte Carlo notes.

4 Implementation: three pricers

Three pricers live in the module `quantlib.asian` (and the C++ mirror).

4.1 The arithmetic IID baseline

Standard MC: simulate n paths of $\{S_k\}_{k=1}^N$ exactly under GBM (no Euler), compute $\bar{S}^{(i)}$ for each, return

$$\hat{C}_n^A \;=\; \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} e^{-rT}\max(\bar{S}^{(i)} - K, 0). \tag{21}$$

Algorithm 1 Arithmetic Asian call by IID Monte Carlo (exact GBM)

Require: Spot S_0, params (K, r, σ, T), monitoring N, sample n.

Compute $h \leftarrow T/N$, drift $\mu \leftarrow (r - \frac{1}{2}\sigma^2)h$, diffusion $\nu \leftarrow \sigma\sqrt{h}$.
for $i = 1, \ldots, n$ **do**
    $S \leftarrow S_0$
    sum $\leftarrow 0$
    for $k = 1, \ldots, N$ **do**
        $Z \leftarrow \mathcal{N}(0, 1)$
        $S \leftarrow S \cdot \exp(\mu + \nu Z)$
        sum $\leftarrow$ sum $+ S$
    end for
    $\bar{S}^{(i)} \leftarrow$ sum$/N$
    $\Pi^{A,(i)} \leftarrow e^{-rT} \max(\bar{S}^{(i)} - K, 0)$
end for
return mean and half-width of $\{\Pi^{A,(i)}\}$.

4.2 The geometric IID estimator (validation)

Same path simulation, but accumulate $\sum \log S_k$ and exponentiate at the end. Used purely to validate the closed form: the IID estimate must agree with C^G from Section 2 within MC error.

4.3 The arithmetic with geometric CV

Run both estimators on the *same paths* (CRN), compute the optimal $\beta^\star$ from sample covariance, and apply the control variate correction. Following the API of `quantlib.variance_reduction`:

$$\hat{C}^A_{\mathrm{CV}} \;=\; \bar{X} - \hat{\beta}^\star(\bar{Y} - C^G), \tag{22}$$

where C^G is the closed-form geometric price. The half-width is computed from the variance of $X - \hat{\beta}^\star Y$, which is $(1 - \hat{\rho}^2)$ times the variance of X.

5 Empirical validation strategy

The script `python/validate_mc_asian.py` runs four tests.

Test 1: closed-form match for geometric Asian. The IID estimator $\hat{C}^G_n$ at $n = 10^5$ should agree with the closed form C^G within 3 half-widths.

Test 2: CV gives huge VRF. Compare half-width of $\hat{C}^A_{\mathrm{CV}}$ vs $\hat{C}^A_{\mathrm{IID}}$ at the same budget. Predicted: VRF > 500 (typical > 1000 at our parameters).

Test 3: empirical correlation. Measure $\hat{\rho}$ between arithmetic and geometric per-path payoffs. Predicted: $\rho > 0.999$.

Test 4: input validation. Mechanical.

6 Contrast with the European-call control variates

The note on control variates treats two examples on the European call: discounted-underlying ($\rho \approx 0.92$, VRF ≈ 7) and asset-or-nothing ($\rho \approx 0.77$, VRF ≈ 2.5). The Asian pricer applies

the same machinery to a different problem and gets a vastly better outcome ($\rho > 0.999$, VRF > 1000).

The lesson is that *control variate quality is determined by the structural relationship between control and target*, not by the sophistication of the technique. The geometric and arithmetic averages of the same set of lognormals differ only at second order in $\sigma\sqrt{T}$, so they share almost all of their noise; they could not help being correlated. The discounted-underlying and the European call payoff are connected only through the indicator function $\mathbf{1}_{\{S_T>K\}}$, so their correlation stops at $\rho \approx 0.92$: about 15% of the variance remains unexplained (VRF ≈ 6.9), against less than 0.1% for the geometric control.

Operational rule. When designing a control variate, look for a problem that shares as much algebraic structure as possible with the target. The Asian-geometric-as-CV-for-Asian-arithmetic is the canonical example of this principle.

7 Bibliographic notes

The geometric-Asian closed form has been re-derived independently many times; the version we use is essentially that of Kemna and Vorst (1990) [1]. The use of the geometric Asian as a control variate for the arithmetic Asian goes back to the same paper. Glasserman [2, Section 4.5] treats the construction at modern length and discusses the limits of the approximation. Asian options are also treated extensively in Hull [3].

References

[1] A. G. Z. Kemna and A. C. F. Vorst, *A pricing method for options based on average asset values*, Journal of Banking and Finance, 14(1):113–129, 1990.

[2] P. Glasserman, *Monte Carlo Methods in Financial Engineering*, Springer, 2004.

[3] J. C. Hull, *Options, Futures, and Other Derivatives*, 10th edition, Pearson, 2018.